encourage and enable India to play that role, it offered assistance and acceptance. The new bonhomie was evident during visits by Nehru to the Soviet Union in June 1955, and by Nikita Khrushchev and Nikolai Bulganin to India in November–December 1955. In India, the Soviet leaders made a number of offers: more economic assistance at better terms; certain kinds of aid (especially scientific and technical) that Moscow seemed less inhibited about giving than Washington; large infrastructure projects, including in the state-owned sector; trade; military equipment; and support for India's position on Kashmir and its claim to Goa.[232] The availability of a Soviet option was particularly welcome to an Indian leadership looking to diversify the country's dependence. Moreover, Indian diplomats in Moscow believed that "a little competition" would help India's case with Washington.[233] And while Nehru expected an "angry reaction" from American policymakers, he also thought that Soviet attention would generate among them "a feeling that India [was] even more important than they [had] thought, [and] far greater efforts should be made to win [India to] their side."[234] But, at least in the near term, that was not the impact Soviet aid had on the US.

American policymakers warily watched the India-Soviet interactions. They believed there were limits to how far the new friendship could go, but saw it as a setback. The India-Soviet bonhomie contributed to skepticism within and outside the administration about aiding an India that supported Chinese and Soviet policies.[235] Returning from a study mission to India, Representative Robert Byrd (D-WV) said the Soviet leaders' trip only highlighted that India was not a dependable country. He said that while he had previously supported aid to India, it was time to "let Mr. Nehru and his people know that those who like to run with the hare and hunt with the hounds just can't get American aid." Representative Adair agreed, criticizing American and Indian officials urging assistance so that India could beat China in the development race.[236] But it was that race that would eventually elicit the more positive American reaction that Nehru had expected.

"Must Not Leave Backdoor Unlatched" (1950–1956)